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SUBMISSION TO THE PANEL ON SECURITY · LEGISLATIVE COUNCIL OF HONG KONG

Wang Fuk Court Fire Inquiry: the record is public, the answers are hard to find

A citizen-built, machine-readable companion to the Independent Committee's published record

To	Members of the Panel on Security, Legislative Council of Hong Kong
From	Wenyun Fu, Lucia Luo and Simon Wang (Wang Fuk Court Fire Report project)
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Subject	Accessibility of the inquiry record ahead of the Committee's final report, due by end of October 2026

1 · Why we are writing

Dear Members,

The Independent Committee on the Wang Fuk Court fire has published its entire evidentiary record — 243 documents, 6,377 pages, some 1.9 million words. We do not question the completeness of that publication; we question its accessibility. The material is filed by the sequence of the Committee's work, not by the seven questions in its Terms of Reference. A resident asking *"was the renovation tender rigged?"* or *"why did the alarms fail?"* cannot obtain an answer from the government's own search box — and never could.

We are a volunteer group of educators and researchers. With open-source tools and AI we rebuilt the whole record: crawled every document, converted all PDFs to searchable text, read the scanned documents by OCR, and tagged every document against the Committee's seven Terms of Reference. The result is a free, bilingual public website (link and QR code below). Most importantly, reading the full text rather than summaries changed the picture dramatically:

11 → 99
documents relevant to bid-rigging and collusion, summary reading vs. full-text reading

8 → 77
documents on the adequacy of laws and penalties (ToR 6)

85
shutdown-renewal notices filed by a contractor who never visited the estate

168
lives lost — the record owes the public at least findability

2 · What this shows

None of the documents described above uses the words "bid-rigging" or "collusion". The evidence residents most want is in oral subcontracts, rubber-stamped inspections and notices filed without a single site visit. It is invisible to keyword search and unreachable through the archive's own structure. The lesson is general: **publication is not accessibility; transparency is not scrutiny.** A machine-readable, question-organised record — achievable at low cost with routine tools — is what turns a public archive into public knowledge.

A note on accuracy: this is a work-in-progress volunteer project built with machine assistance; some figures and classifications may contain errors. Every summary on the website links back to the original PDF, so any claim can be checked at source, and we welcome corrections.

3 · What the coverage shows — and what it cannot answer

A scan of published coverage of the fire through a news-aggregation API, run on 19 October 2026, returned **106 distinct articles published between 26 August and 19 October 2026** — South China Morning Post (24), Dimsum Daily (20), Hong Kong Free Press (8), with China Daily, gov.hk and RTHK at five each. By frame: accountability and the inquiry (41 articles), building safety and regulation (35), politics (33), residents' recovery (15), civil-servant discipline (15). Only 6 articles concern whether the findings will be withheld on privacy grounds.

The same archive searched in Chinese for the estate's own name — 宏福苑 — returns **1,004 matching articles** (505 under an explicit Chinese-language filter) in the same window, against 106 unique English-language articles: Chinese-language coverage of the fire runs several times deeper. Reading a 170-article sample in full, the frames are accountability and the inquiry (109 articles), building safety and works (98), the responsibility of civil servants and departments (88), tendering and bid-rigging (52), recovery and compensation (33), and privacy and redaction (23). Our own first pass at the Chinese coverage returned almost nothing — because we searched a transliteration, not the estate's name. That blind spot is easily fixed for us; for a reporter on deadline it is the difference between citing the inquiry record and paraphrasing it.

The practical point for the Panel is therefore this: the audience reading about the fire most intensively reads in Chinese, yet no Chinese-language outlet can cite the inquiry's own record — the Committee publishes in both languages, but ordered by its working sequence and largely as page images, so there is no way to point a reader to the paragraph that answers *"who approved this tender?"*. Our bilingual site carries a 繁體中文 mirror with Chinese-language search, per-document pages with summaries and key points in Chinese, and every claim traced to a page number and the original PDF. Making the record **citable in Chinese** is the cheapest way to move coverage from anticipation — what the report *may* say — to evidence: what it does say.

What the coverage has in common is that it is **anticipatory**: reports ask what will happen *if* officials are named in the report, and what reforms are planned *ahead of* it. No newsroom can today take a named official, find the statutory duty they held, and point to the paragraphs of the record that bear on it — nor check an announced reform against the Committee's actual recommendation. That is precisely the gap a

question-organised, machine-readable record fills, and it is why accessibility is not a convenience but a condition of accountability.

Two related works in progress support the same point. First, a reply to Alice Wu's opinion of 19 October 2026, which argues that suppressing the Committee's findings on privacy grounds "will convince no one" of the government's commitment to accountability: our draft agrees, and adds that publication with narrow, itemised redactions is necessary but not sufficient — the record must also be *findable*. Second, the coverage scan summarised above is being wired into the project's news page so that the record and the reporting can be read against each other as the report lands.

4 · For journalists: what a modern presentation of the record adds

Half of the audience for the Committee's report is the press, and the press is on deadline. Today a reporter opens 243 PDFs filed in the order the Committee worked, searches a box that cannot find what they need, and falls back on the press release — which is why so much coverage asks what the report *may* say instead of what the record *does* say. Reorganising the same material by question — the way a modern newsroom, database or data desk presents information — changes what can be reported, and routinely surfaces connections that trained readers miss:

- **Search that reads meaning, not keywords.** Tagging every document against the seven Terms of Reference by full-text reading moved bid-rigging and collusion from 11 documents to **99** — and the strongest evidence sits in documents that never use those words.
- **Every claim carries a page number and a link to the original PDF.** A journalist can verify in seconds and cite the inquiry record directly, rather than paraphrasing a summary.
- **A document map and seven Terms-of-Reference narratives.** The story structure is already visible: which departments, contractors and dates recur, and where the record is thin.
- **Bilingual by construction.** The same index in English and 繁體中文, so Chinese-language outlets can quote a paragraph instead of re-reporting the press conference — Chinese coverage of 宏福苑 runs several times deeper than English, and none of it can currently cite the record.
- **Machine-readable output.** Facts can be pulled into a newsroom's own database: our ten-day index of fire-day coverage (595 articles, 26 November – 5 December 2025) was built this way, and shows the appetite for sourced copy.

None of this changes the record; it changes who can use it — and what falls out of it. Our own first pass found tender irregularities in documents no keyword search would return; we expect further insights to surface once the Committee's report is published and the same tools are pointed at it. A question-organised, machine-readable presentation is therefore not a courtesy to journalists: it is how the inquiry's findings get tested, corroborated and, where warranted, acted on.

5 · Our asks of the Panel

1. **Brief the Panel.** Invite the Security Bureau and the Fire Services Department to present the Committee's findings and recommendations as soon as the report is published, and table the report to the Panel.

2. **Fix the shutdown regime.** Ask how shutdowns and restorations of fire service installations will in future be verified by physical inspection — 85 renewal notices were filed with no site visit.
3. **Contractor accountability.** Ask what mechanisms can suspend or debar contractors implicated in the inquiry pending prosecutions.
4. **A public implementation timetable** for the Committee's recommendations, including legislative amendments under its third Term of Reference, with progress reported back to the Panel.
5. **Present the record by Terms of Reference** — so members and the public can trace each recommendation to the underlying evidence, and future inquiries publish machine-readable text alongside their PDFs.

6 · Access the interactive record

The complete reorganised record — every document summarised and searchable, seven Terms-of-Reference narratives, and this report page — is live at:

https://wangfukcourtfirereport.simonsays.hk/engagement/legcoReport.html

Full record and search: https://wangfukcourtfirereport.simonsays.hk/ · Ongoing coverage analysis: https://wangfukcourtfirereport.simonsays.hk/news.html

The page is kept current as the inquiry's final report approaches; the QR code below always points to the latest version.

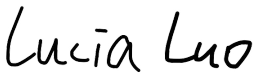
Scan to open the live report page

7 · Signatories



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Disclaimer: The views expressed in this paper are those of the authors. They do not represent the Hong Kong Baptist University and have not been endorsed by the University.